

HTML bloat

Most web pages that you visit, have long unwanted code. This increases the time needed to load the web page

80-20 rule

The 80-20 rule applies to software as well, statisticians claim. 80% of the users, use 20% of the features

application can do all these jobs. More than one messenger client also does not really make sense, but many people have installed the default messenger clients of MSN, Yahoo! and Google.

Free and open source software are generally perceived as being less bloated than their commercial counterparts. One of the most important reason for this is the lack of competition. These software are written for multiple platforms, and often follow the UNIX software design philosophy, which is to write a software for one particular purpose only, and make it streamlined for that purpose. Those who compile the programs they use have the option of leaving out features they deem unnecessary. In the commercial software arena, the rules of the game are entirely different.

A DVD burner with the ability to transcode data is perceived as being better than a DVD burner that does not. This may seem like a minor addition on the surface, but adds significantly to the system's software footprint. There are a number of video and audio formats to choose from, and a host of codecs for each of those formats. Every added feature significantly bloats up the software.

Why bloatware should bother you

Bloatware may eat up essential system resources from the task at hand. Alternatives are more streamlined for your purposes, run faster, and give you better results. If all you do with software such as Photoshop is a little cropping, adding captions and colour correction, Paint.net will do the job using less than half the resources, and never running out of scratch disk space. On a desktop this may seem unimportant, but on laptops and netbooks with limited processing power and hard disk space, this becomes absolutely vital.

Another important aspect is privacy and bandwidth usage. Windows Media Player from Microsoft, and the CS3 suite by Adobe, are both known to have sent discreet packets of data over the net, with details on usage. While the license agreements state that personal information is not collected in this usage, and that it is done solely to improve the software itself, they are taking up a small portion of your bandwidth. Software from lesser companies have been called spyware for doing exactly the same.

Automated updates often take up a considerable share of the bandwidth. Weekly definition updates of most antivirus software is somewhere in the range of 20 MB. For careful users, who are smart about their external drives and web habits, this is just a waste of space and bandwidth.

Dangers of using alternatives

Bloatware is also a relative term. Expert users and professionals often use obscure features that the lay user may not need. A certain alternative to the bloatware in question may not work as well as the bloatware for some applications. For example, Foxit Reader, a widely touted replacement for the bloated Adobe Acrobat Reader, cannot handle embedded forms as well as Acrobat Reader can.

While bloatware alternatives may not collect usage data, have no licensing process involved, and carry a minimum file size, they are more difficult to use than the commercial or bloated alternatives. Paint.net and Gimp, both alternatives to Photoshop, depend heavily on plug-ins for added functionality. You can do everything you can on Photoshop, but only if you hunt down the plug-ins for the purpose and install it. This increases the footprint of the software, but you get to customise it the way you want, with the features you want. Most new users of either of these software are either unaware of the existence of these plug-ins, or unwilling to take the trouble to find and install the ones they need. There is no correct approach to this problem, and it depends heavily on the individual users.

The direction that the development of the software takes, may not be the same as the direction the alternatives take. For example, although Photoshop CS4 allows users to work with 3D models, it's unlikely that Paint.net or Gimp will ever add such functionality to their releases. The formats used by bloatware, are also not always supported by the alternatives.

Some software have "lite" versions, with reduced features. Some installation procedures allow for undesirable processes to be removed, including an option to send in usage data. Often, as in the case of VLC or Winamp, the previous versions of the software are less bloated and preferable to the newer versions. All these aspects have to be considered before choosing the software you want; this is a guide to choose the best one for your usage.

Media players

Most users prefer to use a different software for viewing music and video. The default for both in modern windows systems is Windows Media Player. Windows Media Player takes unusually long to open files, is slow to respond, buggy when handling large files and can handle a very limited number of codecs to start with. VLC, one installed, would be godsend to many, simply because users were able to play videos encoded using obscure codecs. K-lite mega codec

pack, along with Windows Media Player classic should do the trick now. Media Player Classic handles QuickTime and real player formats. The latter better than the latest version of VLC. It is fast, simple, and minimalist, a design philosophy that VLC seems to have drifted away from. The older version of VLC, 0.7.0, can still handle most videos, and is a 5 MB install.

Audio players are more complicated. Winamp has become the *de facto* due to the wide range of skins available, and for being around for such a long time. However, the latest version of the player forces a lot

of features on you. The media library, for example, is a constant irritant. There is no way to get rid of it, unless you choose the classic skin. The newer skins are also heavy on resources. Feature bloat was a problem ever since version 5.0 came out, which was a long time after 3.0, and skipping everything 4.x, because that is how much Winamp had changed. Not everyone welcomed the change, and a lot of tech enthusiasts prefer the older version of Winamp. Typically, they use whatever 2.x series is available to them. 2.95 is the last version in the 2.x series, but an interesting release was the 2.666 version, which enthusiasts prefer merely for the connotations in the version number. 3.0 was another release, the only one in the short lived 3.x series. A lot of users swear by the 3.0 version also, a suitable compromise between the simplicity of the earlier versions, and the feature set in the later versions. However, finding skins for 3.0 is a difficult thing now, and it does not support 2x skins.

An alternative to Winamp, and another media player which has its own fan following among techies is Foobar2000. This software is small, functional, and the tinkerer's dream as it can be customised in a hundred different ways. Foobar2000 is one of the few software that has struck the right balance between default features and plug-ins. There are many plug-ins available, but these are not overwhelming in number and are for highly specific features.

Download managers

The default download managers for most browsers, are not aggressive in the sense of consuming bandwidth. Even without any other internet activity, these browsers typically download using just a single connection with the server. Multi-threaded download managers connect multiple times to the same server, and download data faster. This was the reason download managers such as FileZilla, Free Download Manager and Orbit Downloader showed up in the first place. However, modern download managers require some added features beyond mere

Yagni

The Yagni Principle: The You Ain't Gonna Need It principle encourages coders to not put in functionality unless the software absolutely needs it.